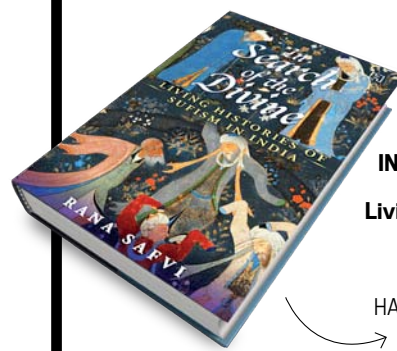
An outsider in Bollywood, Ali devotes a chapter each to five films: *Gaman* (1978), *Umrao Jaan*, *Aagaman* (1982), *Anjuman* (1986) and *Zooni*, which was never released. Here he details his artistic adventures, emphasising music as much as he does production design and costumes. Though he touches upon how the feminine became a forte of his work, he doesn't elaborate on why. In hindsight, he attributes it to women's "deeper continuity of culture", which is integral to his own "way of expressing things". Some might also find unnecessary his penchant for possessions. Letting go of his father's car, an Isotta Fraschini, is hard and there is joy in getting horses. "Muzaffar Ali, the person, is a foolish child," he says. "I love things that are beautiful... They keep me amused. I see things a little extra." That "extra", though, has led to an artist who is aware of his own pitfalls. Ali talks about the struggle of separating a creative pursuit from commercial trappings and reflects on his failures. "I have not compromised. I left things when I found I was being trapped," he says. As he distanced himself from the "cauldron of insecurity and ugliness" that Bollywood can often be, he was swept by Sufism, the "creative rudder" that liberates him. At 78, Ali paints and feels that he still has a film in him. He also designs and collaborates with musicians and dancers. "Just don't call me a jack of all trades," he pleads with a laugh. ■

Suhani Singh

BOOKS

TREADING THE SUFI'S PATH

RANA SAFVI's new book is a work of thorough scholarship but it is also a labour of love



IN SEARCH OF THE DIVINE: Living Histories of Sufism in India
by Rana Safvi
HACHETTE INDIA
₹599; 432 pages

The minute one thinks of Sufism, writes scholar Rana Safvi in her book, one that is both descriptive and interpretative, "the two strong images that come to mind are qawwalis and Melvana Jalaluddin Rumi's mystical verses". The qawwali, developed in the 13th century by Amir Khusro, is embedded in our popular culture and was once a must-have in every Bollywood movie. Rumi, founder of the Mevlavi Sufi (1207–1273), was a poet and scholar, described by the *New Yorker* as "the bestselling poet in the United States". His couplets feature in the albums of artistes as varied as Chris Martin of Coldplay and Madonna.

Coleman Baker, Rumi's translator, recites this from Rumi in one of Coldplay's albums: "*This being human is a guest house/ Every morning a new arrival/ A joy, a depression, a meanness,/ some momentary awareness comes/ as an unexpected visitor.*" But, of course, there is more to Sufism than qawwalis and Rumi, and Safvi's meticulous research gives us a view of both its depth and width.

When a system communicates largely in similes and metaphors, it is either misunderstood or it invites different interpretations. Asked to explain the highest form of religious devotion, the Sufi saint Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti said, "Develop a river-like generosity, sun-like bounty an earth-like hospitality." Most religions gain strength from the poetic nature of their utterances; there is both beauty and richness in this. But there is also the scope for ambiguity.

Safvi clarifies some of the misconceptions surrounding the term 'Sufi' and traces the origins of Sufism and its spread in India through two streams: history and legend on the one hand, and personal experiences on the other. The latter includes "field visits to the dargahs across India". She brings to this task the rigour of a scholar and the awareness of a populariser. The result is an erudite, depth-seeking tome that also serves as an introductory volume to the precepts and practices of Sufism.

"Sufism," says Safvi, "is a vast ocean of mystical thoughts, doctrines, literature and poetry, and a legacy of its saints." It has always been a part of Islam, although Orientalists of the 19th century saw it as something distinct from it. Sufism both contributed to and absorbed from India's syncretic culture. It also went through the occasional dip. During one such dip, Persian scholar Abu Al-Hasan Fushanja wrote, "Sufism today is a name without a reality, whereas it was once a reality without a name."

IN SEARCH OF THE DIVINE includes a chapter on women Sufis and the contribution of women to Sufism

Today, it is both a name and a reality, something the author captures well. As the Sufi mystics came to India and settled down here, they were influenced by the local Hinduism. There was a great and constant cross-fertilisation of ideas, says Safvi.

In Search of the Divine is clearly a labour of love and includes a chapter on women Sufis and the contribution of women to Sufism. However, there are dargahs where even today women are not allowed. The patriarchy is deep-rooted, but occasionally shows signs of loosening its grip. ■

Suresh Menon

